

- Are issues like disk storage features and bandwidth still a point of discussion?

Some of the most important factors that an IT head needs to take into consideration while choosing a hosting service provider are listed below.

Thoroughly analyse your hosting needs

First and foremost, before evaluating the Web hosting service provider, IT heads should know their firm's needs. Shashank Mehrotra, GM and business head, BigRock, explains, "Depending upon the kind of business needs one has, hosting can have many different components to it. Different kinds of organisations of different sizes have different needs. For example, a large IT company looking to deploy a very significant application will have different needs than someone who just wants to set up a regular website. So one needs to analyse the kind of requirements one will have before selecting a hosting service."

Broadly speaking, hosting services can be classified into three categories: shared hosting, virtualised hosting and dedicated hosting. Shared hosting is when you are co-located with other customers on the same server. Virtualised hosting is also when you are co-located—you use virtual machines and have access to many of the attributes and benefits. However, it fundamentally operates as if you are the only user of the device. While dedicated hosting is where the user gets complete access. Mehrotra shares, "Users also need to choose whether they want to go for Windows hosting or Linux hosting, as these are the two most popular flavours. There are further levels of customisation within these options. If you are building a custom application, you need a LAMP stack. Also, for building a website, which content management system do you need? This and other such questions need to be answered. I think, for a particular use case, one needs to figure out what the apt hosting product for that would be. There are a number of criteria that can affect your decision. One should analyse all of them first, before choosing the hosting service provider."

IT heads are advised to first thoroughly understand their needs by evaluating certain questions like: What kind of website is being built? Are Windows applications important? Is a special version of software needed? How much scalability will the website require with respect to the Web traffic volume? Does the website need special software? And many more.

Once these basic questions are answered, IT heads should look at the roadmap for the website over the next 12 months. If your company is just venturing into Web hosting, it's advisable to keep things simple and go for a shared hosting account, as it is affordable and easy to maintain. It is good enough for new sites and once the traffic picks up, you can easily upgrade to Virtual Private Server (VPS) or dedicated hosting.

Service consistency

Chandaliya says, "The second most important factor when it comes to choosing the right Web hosting service

is consistency. The way the hosting and cloud industry has grown and continues to grow, many new players are emerging as hosting providers. Most of them are purely infrastructure providers and have invested heavily to build large infrastructure. Many have no experience in offering technical support. Building infrastructure and providing it on lease is one aspect of the hosting business; however, providing technical support and application uptime is the most important aspect of this industry. So while choosing a solution provider, it is important to check if the provider has consistently provided technical support services and delivered application level uptime."

Pay for usage

Payment based on consumption is the third important aspect. There are two payment models in hosting -- one is 'pay-per-allocation' and the second is 'pay-per-consume'. Pay-per-allocation means paying for whatever resources are allocated to you, irrespective of whether you use them or not. Chandaliya advises, "In the pay-per-consume model, you pay for whatever you use. One can understand the pay-per-allocation model by looking at the real estate market. If you lease some property, you have to pay for that, irrespective of whether you used it or not. An analogy for the pay-per-consume model is electricity bills, where you pay for whatever amount of power you use. In our industry, there are providers who invoice for allocation like the co-location service, cloud infrastructure, etc. Customers pay for the amount of compute and storage capacity assigned. And there are a few providers who invoice based on consumption, where customers pay for the amount of compute capacity and storage actually used out of the allocation. So while selecting the provider, this factor is very important, as you should pay only for the amount of resources you use, like any utility model."

Executive dashboard

Yet another aspect that must be looked at while selecting the right hosting provider is the provision of an executive dashboard. It is really important to monitor the availability of your services. The ultimate goal of any hosting service is to get better uptime of applications in order to serve end customers consistently and generate revenue. So it becomes vital to be able to monitor the uptime of services. In order to know whether your firm is getting the most out of the Web hosting service, it is very important to get an executive dashboard for monitoring, from the service provider. Every role in an organisation requires different levels of monitoring. Some hosting providers offer a monitoring interface. IT administrators need the hosting service provider to monitor hardware and its parameters like RAM, CPU, disk and bandwidth usage. CIOs/CTOs require end-to-end monitoring of application availability. They need a dashboard to monitor